

Chapter 5

Tayna didn't know how long she ran for. For a time, it was effortless as dark melded into light, paws pounding rock and coarse turf alike in her headlong flight. Magic, innately welded into the very fibre of her being, lent strength to her paws. She didn't have to think about it and for that she was glad. If she had to concentrate on whatever magic she had like she had in the training grounds and with that godforsaken pebble, she wasn't sure she would have gotten very far at all.

The ground proved treacherous underfoot as she fled, leaping rocks and crags with ease that surprised her. It was almost as if she remembered the movements from a past life. Tayna flinched, reminded that she probably did. Muscle memory and all that. Yet she still wished to have those memories between her ears if only to make sense of them all.

As dawn cast a golden glow over the mountains, her eyes flickered from her path over and over again, jaw slowly falling slack at the sheer, raw beauty laid out before her. Rocky mountains split the sky, impossibly high, and it was all she could do to not clasp her paws to her chest and stand in sheer awe of them. There was little to no vegetation and only a thin, rough layer of grass clung to the slopes as if in obstinate defiance of the harsh environment. From time to time, she raced past stunted, scrub-like trees and bushes, branches tucked in for protection unlike the great pines and beeches she was used to. The vixen swallowed. The mountains were a very different world. And yet one she would have to survive in.

She paused to drink at a winding creek, dropping to her knees and thirstily scooping up water in the cup of her paw. She'd brought nothing with her but the sharpened dagger strapped to her hip, the shield on her back and the sword on her opposite hip and the clothes she wore. Tayna trembled. It seemed hasty in hindsight yet she'd been chased off with a scowl and a slap when she'd tried to take extra food from the mess hall. All she had managed to filch was a small skin intended to hold wine or mead or any kind of liquor.

Paw shaking, she dipped it carefully below the surface of the clear water and watched as bubbles jostled to the surface, bursting into non-existence as she filled the brown skin. She shoved the stopper back in, jamming it in as tightly as she was able, and was on her way again, shaking her hair back from her shoulders.

It was not long, however, before the figurative dogs barked at her heels. As she ran without aim or purposes, except to push herself far, far away, it was a simple feat for the Alliance to realise that she was not using the most efficient routes through the mountains. As much as Tayna tried to skirt the foot of each monstrous peak, the twisting route through steep valleys and deep gorges slowed her vastly, even with her increased strength. She heard them following – a dull rancour of shouting and clanging. She shuddered. It was as if they were trying to flush a fox out of a hole.

She considered making like one of her four-legged kind, the foxes that had not evolved to walk on two legs with greater intelligence, but the bare mountainsides offered no holes to dive into nor nooks to cradle her limbs. As she ran, she shook, at first so little that her exhaustion was barely noticeable. And yet it grew irrevocably until each step came with a great force of will and effort. The pads of her paws ached and tears streamed down her muzzle as she ducked into the hollow beneath a massive fallen tree to shiver and rest. The

trees leaves had long dropped from its branches after its felling but its roots curved darkly towards the cloudy sky, grey clouds roiling and scudding with great haste.

Tayna put her head in her paws, ears pricked. The Alliance were quiet – the hunting party with silence on their lips for once. She couldn't be sure if it was a blessing or a curse that she found them quiet. Where were they? Her heart hammered. Close? Far? Given up? Wouldn't she wish!

It would be so easy to give up, Tanya thought as she staggered upright, pushing off the rotting log with all the strength she had left in her arm. I could stop now and let them catch me. It'd all be over then.

The words stirred something in her chest. All over? Back to the Alliance and working from dawn past dusk on magic she had no idea how to control or even reliably use? Everything was a fluke, if it even happened at all! The thought of Devan's rolling eyes soured her gaze and, steadying herself, she scrambled away from the fallen tree and flung herself down the side of the valley towards the rush of water.

Giving up wasn't an option. Her lips twisted. Let them try to catch her. She had reason to flee. And what use did they have for her? A tool in their underground war? She could have scoffed at the ridiculousness of it all and her derision lent energy to her paws, using the natural decline of the slope to speed up.

There was no sense in being caught and trapped like a fox yet again. Tayna's nose twitched. She was out now and there was *no* going back.

She splashed into the stream at the bottom of the valley, soaking her leggings as water poured into her calf-length boots. They were stolen, of course, but she yelped at the cold, clapping her paw instantly over her muzzle. It was a moment too late.

Scuffles and whispers emanated from further down the fallen and Tayna leapt on to the bank, ducking low-hanging branches with the wild-eyed sprint of a cornered beast. The river masked her passage and she stumbled through the undergrowth until she came face to face with the source of the crashing water. The river began as a waterfall pouring from the rock face, pounding down into a deep plunge pool below. Framed by moss-covered rocks, it would have been a scene of raw beauty at any other time.

Tayna gulped and peered into the water. There was no telling how deep it was. No swimming it either with that waterfall above it.

The vixen stiffened. Members of the Alliance – voices she didn't recognise – shouted and slammed the flats of their paws over what could have been tautly stretched animal skins, back down the valley where she had been only a short time ago. She listened intently, trying to discern their purpose. Yes, animal skins acting as drums made the most sense, used to flush out prey with the noise and clamour. The predators still hunted as they would so it was not uncommon for them to be. Prey animals with the typical intelligence of those walking on two legs, however, were a little more skittish over using the body parts of other animals. Tayna just thought that there was a difference between those lacking intelligence and those who at least pretended to have it. Sometimes those labelled beasts were less beastlike than the two-legged intelligent species. Just like the ones creeping closer to her tail.

Shimmying over the nearest rock, she ducked out of sight, only the tip of her nose and worried eyes showing over the edge of the rock. There was no movement in the vegetation and yet her heart drummed a sickening beat against her ribcage. There was no escape. Her paws slipped on the rock and she blinked as spray and foam flew into her eyes. She craned her head to look at the sheer rock face, wondering if there were enough nooks and crannies for fingers and toes to scramble up. Yet she could only see her broken body smashed over the rocks if she tried.

Tayna closed her eyes and pressed her forehead to the damp, rough rock, moss tickling her cheek. It was hopeless. If she hid, would they not find her? Tayna mind raced, desperate. Where wouldn't they look for her? Was there anywhere the Alliance wouldn't hunt her down? Somewhere too dangerous for them to consider her hiding?

“Oi! You! Vixen!”

Tayna gulped for breath, eyes bulging out of their sockets. She didn't even hear the voice, scanning the valley for her adversaries, any rustling of undergrowth that may have preluded their arrival. There was nowhere to run and nowhere to hide that wouldn't kill her. The vixen clutched at her throat, breath coming sluggishly. It was the end – she wasn't getting out of this one without being hauled back to the Alliance.

A stone hit her on the head. Tayna whipped around, a feral snarl breaking her lips.

“Sheesh, no need to show your teeth.”

She pricked her ears, attention caught. An equine with a muzzle that took no prisoners peered over the rock, ignorant to the water seeping between his hoof-tipped fingers. His black paws tightened on his perch and he thrust his pale yellow-cream head forward, nostrils flaring. A short, black mane that stuck straight up from the back of his neck and head swayed in the breeze from the waterfall's passing.

The blocky-headed horse snorted and blew snot over the rock, ears warily pinned back. Her eyes dropped to the trembling dagger in one paw, pointed directly at her as if she had become yet another target.

“Are you friend or foe?” He asked.

Tayna eyed the dagger contemptuously. As if she couldn't just flick it aside. Well, if her magic complied, that was.

“I'd like to say friend but I don't even know anymore.”

“Are they after you?” He jerked his head at the rising scuffling in the bushes. “What've you done to get on their bad side? Stolen something? You with the Church?”

His eyes widened and he yanked his head back.

“Wait...no. That's it. I've gone and answered my own darn question again.” He ground his teeth together, grey nose wrinkling. “I recognise *you*. You're one of the Church's puppets.”

Tayna growled, ears flipping back.

“Not any more I’m not,” she declared. “And I’m not with the damn Alliance either, before you ask. I’m just trying to get away and get home.”

He studied her.

“I don’t believe you.”

“Why would you?” Tanya shot back bitterly. “No one does. Not even when I tell them that I don’t remember a damn thing. Everyone thinks I’m lying so why would you be any different?”

The equine parted his lips as if to say more and then abruptly shut his mouth, muscles tense.

“Tuck? What’s going on here?”

A small pair of pointed ear-tips came into view beside Tuck’s shoulder, white and with fluffy tufts at the tips.

“So that’s your name,” Tayna murmured.

The twitching ears rose higher, allowing Tayna the first good look at the female’s face. And what she saw had her shrinking back, eyes wide. Her fox-like muzzle was as white as snow on the mountaintops but she had a ruff of fur framing her cheeks, puffing them out beyond what would be normal for any natural vulpine. Her ears were too narrow to be vulpine also, rising several inches up from her skull and positioned in a similar way to a rabbit’s atop her head.

On closer inspection, her snout was too narrow and fine to be fox-like either but Tayna struggled to relate her to any other species she was familiar with. The one disturbingly discerning feature on her muzzle was the black marking framing her eyes. They seemed to angle ever so slightly in to her eyes, the waves drawing the watcher in and in until they fell into the sapphire pools.

Tayna shivered. Sapphire wasn’t a natural colour. It was a *magic* colour. She knew of this species, although she had never seen one before. Her mother had called them Estrel, once upon a time. It had been a long time since she’d been told fairy tales about their magical prowess and wild natures, however.

“This is one of the Chosen, Fayla. Let’s be on our way.” He scratched the back of his neck, fingers ruffling through his coarse mane. “She’s trouble, trouble to us.” He frowned. “Don’t even know what one of them is doing all the way out here. Either way...let’s leave her to whatever fate is awaiting her.”

Fayla’s lips twisted with concern and, ignoring Tuck, she peered further over the rock at the cowering vixen.

“Tuck, she’s shivering...look at her. She can’t mean any harm.”

Tuck shook his head vehemently and jabbed a finger at Tayna. The stubby hoof at his fingertip was cracked down the middle.

“I don’t care. She’s one of them, Fayla, don’t you see?”

The creature folded her arms, pointed ears slipping back halfway. Yet she was not subdued.

“All I see is a scared fox. What do you see?”

“One of the Chosen.”

“Maybe so.” Fayla conceded. “But, right now, she’s scared and out on her own. She’s coming with us.”

“Fayla!”

Ignoring him, Fayla stretched her lithe body out over the rock and reached down as far as she could, paw waving back and forth as she struggled to keep her balance.

“Grab my paw,” she said with a small smile. “It’s okay, I promise. We’re not going to do anything bad to you.”

She looked back over Tayna’s shoulder.

“But we have to move – *now*. They’re almost upon us.” Fayla stretched further, urgency flashing through her eyes. “Quickly!”

Tayna made her decision in a split second and lunged for Fayla’s paw. The Estrel clung on to her and nearly toppled over the rock herself, only caught in time by a curse and Tuck’s large paw. Hauling them both up and over the rock face, the horse snorted and blew snot over Tayna’s shirt as her chest heaved, shoulders set back. The decision had been made.

Shaking his head, Tuck shrugged a cloth pack more comfortably up on to his shoulder, straps running under his armpits.

“You’re coming with us then,” he said, eyes rolling so far back that they almost completely disappeared into his skull. “Earth forbid it... Fayla, if she turns on us...”

He pressed his lips into a hard line, looking down his nose at the Estrel who hopped from hind paw to paw, long tail lashing. It snaked back and forth like a feline’s, although it was tipped with a long, draping tuft of hair that ran several inches down the length from the tapered tip. Tayna’s eyes followed it hypnotically.

“It will not come to that,” Fayla assured him, taking Tayna’s paw. “I’m sure you have a tale to tell us but we must be going... What was your name?”

Tayna licked her lips, mouth dry as the two turned their eyes on her. Tuck opened his mouth although no sound came out, expecting himself to know the answer to the question before truly listening to it.

“Tayna.”

The name came out as a whisper, rasping through her hoarse throat. Fayla leaned in closer, cupping her ear to listen. The vixen took a deep breath.

“My name...is Tayna.”

*

Sitting cross-legged before a crackling fire, Tayna cradled a clay mug between two paws and sipped water flavoured with herbs. Mint? She had not known that mint still grew wild, only ever finding it in the estate gardens. She stared into the cup forlornly as leaves swirled through the shadow below the surface of the water, appearing darker than they truly were.

The unlikely duo, bickering like siblings the whole way, led Tayna along routes she would never have found alone and out of harm's way. Slowly but surely, the noise of the Alliance hunting party faded into the distance as they clung to the rock face, ducking behind the waterfall and letting the water wash away their tracks.

Only a short distance along the cliff was a rockier section where the rock had broken away gradually, worn from weather and time. With a greater number of gouges in the rock, Fayla and Tuck were able to scoot up with no problem at all. Expecting Tayna to experience more difficulty, Tuck threw down a rope for her only to find the vixen standing only slightly out of breath right next to him. Her cheeks glowed with heat and she shot back from cliff edge, away from her enemies.

She lost track of their winding route, watching Fayla's heels as lethargy set in like the inevitable creep of the rising tide. There was no escaping exhaustion, even for one like her. When she made it to the cave, Fayla grabbed her shoulders and steered her down on to all fours, making her crawl down a damp tunnel that scraped down the length of her back until she emerged into a comparatively dry cavern.

Collapsing at the back of the cavern, Tayna murmured her apologies as Fayla and Tuck bustled around, setting up camp in a more efficient manner than she could have ever managed. When the mug of revitalising water infusion was pressed into her paw, she did not complain but only drank obediently as Tuck prepared dinner. His tail flicked, long, black hairs swatting invisible flies in silent agitation. Tayna sighed. It didn't take a mind reader to figure he didn't want her there.

Tayan stroked her cup and surveyed her companions with as much wariness as Tuck afforded her.

“What do you know about me then?”

Tayna did her best to conceal the tremble from her voice. Fayla started, tail swishing around the cave floor and looping over her ankle. She did not wear shoes and her long, flexible toes curled towards the warmth of the fire. The Estrel leaned forward, sitting with her legs tucked beneath her.

“Shouldn’t you be the one telling us about you?”

The vixen rubbed her throat and sipped from her cup, if but for something to do.

“Not really sure what I can tell you,” she said honestly. “I woke up...maybe a moon ago? I lost track of time. I woke up some time ago and was in the keep controlled by the Alliance on the mountainside. Do you know about it?”

Fayla and Tuck shook their heads. Kindling snapped in the fear and Tayna glanced up to follow the trail of smoke curling out of a hole in the roof. They weren’t all that far underground, although the top of the cave dipped into darkness.

“Maybe they keep it hidden. I’ve never been outside the keep in daylight. They told me that I was skilled in magic but had lost the ability to use this magic, that I had powers.” She frowned. “They told me that I was one of the Chosen but I don’t have any memory of this. I still don’t know if this is true. How can I?”

Tuck snorted.

“No memories at all?”

Tayna shook her head and stared between her knees, pointed outwards as she sat with her legs crossed.

“I know it sounds ridiculous...” She bit her lip, fighting down the tears that threatened to well up. “They didn’t believe me either. They had me in the training grounds, at first, fighting every day. That wasn’t so bad, not in hindsight.”

She paused, rubbing beneath her eye.

Damn it...

“I had a friend there. Or, at least, she used to be my friend. I could fight with her in the training grounds, even if she didn’t want me there. She was pretty good too.”

Tayna chuckled.

“I got better and better at fighting though. They eventually caught on to it and said that my powers – whatever those actually are – were coming back. Then they drilled me through magic training again and again and again...”

The vixen trailed off, inhaling deeply and slowly.

“But that’s over now. I escaped. There’s nothing more to tell.”

“Did you kill anyone when you escaped?” Tuck asked, stirring a pot hanging from a spit above the fire. “Doesn’t sound like an easy task to get out of a keep swarming with the Alliance.”

Fayla swatted his arm.

“Tuck!”

“What?”

Tayna chuckled, surprised at her own amusement.

“It’s okay...really. I don’t mind. I’d ask the same questions if I was you.”

The vixen ruffled up her hair, combing her fingers through the unruly strands. A twig stuck out from the back of her head and she grimaced as she worked it loose.

“I didn’t kill anyone,” she answered at least, dropping the twig on the floor. “I watched the guards to see when they changed shifts. Once they had me in magic training, they didn’t seem to care where I went about the keep. Or maybe that was more the fact that Devan was supposed to be watching me. Once he was done with me, he didn’t care what I did.”

She moistened her lips with the tip of her tongue.

“If someone had been watching more closely, I don’t think I would have gotten out. All in all, it was surprisingly easy.” She smirked, eyes crinkling at the corners. “All in all, the Alliance is more concerned with keeping others out rather than locking them within the walls of that keep. I think they may have wanted to consider that a little more than they did.”

The vixen laughed, a chuckle bubbling up before she could stop it. It was strange to laugh and she rubbed her throat, unused to the sensation.

Fayla poked the fire with a long, blackened stick, letting the sparks crackle and jump between logs. The Estrel’s tail flicked and wound sinuously around her calf, brushing up her fur in the wrong direction where her leggings had ridden up.

“I’ve seen you...once,” Fayla said, screwing up her muzzle. “It was from a distance and I couldn’t be sure. But I’ve never heard of any other foxes being that kind of magic user with the Church. You must have been the only one.”

“Foxes are hardly uncommon,” Tuck interjected with a snort. “It could have been anyone.”

Fayla rocked back, fingers curled around her ankles as she kept her balance, heels up and off the ground.

“And how many of the Chosen do you know?”

The equine blew hot air but had no answer, grumbling as he stirred the pot above the fire. He looked down at it suspiciously. Clear it was not cooking swiftly enough for his liking. Food often did that around hungry equines.

Tayna hesitated, a question lingering on the tip of her tongue.

“Did you...” She stopped, rewording the sentence in her head. “What was I doing? Was I...” She looked down, the corners of her eyes stinging with something she would not admit to. “Was I evil?”

The word sounded childish on her lips and she regretted it almost as soon as she said it. It was foolish, of course it was. Everyone knew what Chosen did on a daily basis, performing miracles for a corrupt church. Once, Tayna had even begged her mother to go see one of them perform in a city. She couldn’t remember its name though, being too young to remember anything of note beyond what play she had in store for the day and who had annoyed her most recently.

Fayla fingered the side of her narrow snout, taking her time in answering while Tuck kept his head down and sullenly stirred the pot. Tayna’s eyes followed the hypnotic motion.

“I was not close...” Fayla repeated slowly, carefully, “but you were performing great feats of magic. It was for performance purposes – nothing like what we’d do on our travels out here. There were lots of flashing lights – it was dusk – and you made the elements obey your wishes like it was nothing, nothing at all. There didn’t seem to be anything you couldn’t do but I saw you there, wrapped in storm clouds as lightning broke through. It scored a deep crack in the ground and the crowd close to you screamed something awful.”

Fayla chuckled in memory.

“But everyone was impressed by you, I can tell you that much with all certainty. You seemed to be one of the best, even if I couldn’t see everything you were doing.”

The Estrel’s face fell all of a sudden and she moodily flicked her tail out away from her body, playing with a stuck together tuft of fur on her ankle.

“Estrel are naturally skilled with magic yet there is no chance I could ever come close to what you did back then.” She looked Tayna over with a newfound respect glinting in her eyes. “I don’t think even Tuck would be able to explain the mechanics of what you did. And he’s the best at knowing what’s what.”

The horse grumbled and flicked her with his tail.

“Yet with little magic to speak of.”

“You have plenty of magic,” Fayla assured him, her paw on his shoulder. “We play to one another’s strengths.” She smiled. “It is good that we came across one another. You could say that we even complement each other.”

The horse turned his head away and Tayna swore the insides of his dark ears lightened with the suggestion of pink. She leaned forward, ears pricked sharply.

“You...know how to use magic?” Tayna imposed, slipping between them in conversation, ever more the outsider. “How? How can you use it?”

Tuck shrugged.

“It’s something you know, if you can use it. There’s different sides to it though. I can’t sense magical potential but I’m good at gathering essence. I’m good at knowing how to combine... I suppose you would call them spells.”

Tayna sighed and slumped, rolling her shoulders forward, head spinning already. Spells? There were spells?

“That’s a lot more than I’ll ever know,” she said, tugging at her hair. “I wish I knew. If I have magic...I may as well know how to use it. It could keep me safe. Keep me away from the Alliance.”

Tuck surveyed her. Tayna wondered if the distrust would ever completely melt from his eyes. Yet she knew, in her heart, that she didn’t trust the two of them either, even if they had saved her from the Alliance. Her stomach churned at not being self-sufficient and she vowed, silently, to use their knowledge to at least understand more about the mountain range. Maybe then she wouldn’t be the fox down the hole when the Alliance hunting party chased after her russet tail again.

The horse cleared his throat, coughing lightly into his closed fist, which he brought close to his lips.

“I can show you how to use your magic...in part,” Tuck stared, doubt clouding his tone. “Don’t know if it’ll do any good though. Or if it’s wise to show you... Maybe gathering essence wouldn’t be so bad?”

He talked as if to himself.

“No danger in that... Basic thing. Yes.”

Tayna leaned forward, the white tip of her tail flicking back and forth. Her ears pricked. Gathering essence? Excitement bubbled in her stomach. It was already more than that dolt Devan had ever told her about magic.

Tuck sat up straighter, rocking back on his rump, tail fanned out across his sleeping mat.

“All magic stems from essence, essentially.” He spread his paws wide as if to demonstrate. “If you have never tried to do that, I can’t think of where you’re finding the basic energy to perform magic.

“It’s erratic,” Tayna confessed. “The mage who taught me – I use the term very loosely – didn’t really teach me anything. So it just came when I was angry or upset. And what’s essence?”

Tuck stared, unblinking.

“You don’t even know that?”

Tayna flushed.

“No... Is that bad?”

The equine mumbled to himself, running his fingers over the backs of his paws, tracing the natural lines and direction of his coat. It had fluffed up some in the warm and dry.

“You must have been drawing from your own life essence,” he muttered, eyeing her up and down. “Or you had enough essence stored from your time as a Chosen that you could pick away at it whenever times dictated it necessary. To think that you haven’t been actively drawing from it...”

He sighed heavily and scratched behind his ear.

“You’re going to learn how to use essence, vixen,” he said, leaving no room for argument. “And then, maybe, just maybe...you’ll be able to use that magic of yours. And not be at risk of setting everything on fire or something idiotic like that.”

He cracked his knuckles, one by one, and peered into the pot above the fire as it bubbled away merrily. The conversation, very clearly, was over and done with in his eyes.

For once, Tayna did not want to argue. Her heart warmed as Fayla passed out vegetarian bowls of brothy soup and she slurped it down as if it was her last meal. Leafy greens followed and she did not lament the lack of meat, her stomach full and sated for the first time in days. She sat back against the cave wall and let her eyelids droop, safe and secure in the knowledge that she was tucked away in the warm while the Alliance were outside, her presence unknown.

The vixen smiled. Sleep claimed her as the murmur of conversation around her grew fainter and fainter, Tuck and Fayla weaving taller and taller tales in a bid to outdo one another. The Estrel giggled musically, tail sweeping round to tickle Tanya’s shoulder. She’d slumped all the way back on to a temporary padding of pack and blanket that served as her sleeping mat for the moment.

The last thing she felt before slipping into a dreamless sleep was Fayla’s soft paws tugging a coarse blanket up under her chin. The vixen’s hind paws stuck out the bottom, yet she could not bring herself to care.

Maybe things were looking up after all.